

Censorship without borders: Deconstructing the myth of West vs. East

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Summary

This report critically re-examines the global landscape of online censorship, emphasizing its evolving and multidimensional nature. Far from being confined to overt suppression in authoritarian regimes, censorship manifests wherever (geo)political, economic, and cultural incentives converge, including in the more subtle regulatory and commercial suppression of information in democracies. While countries like China and Russia employ explicit, state-driven mechanisms – such as firewalls, deep packet inspection, and legal mandates – to block and punish disfavored content, Western democracies increasingly rely on subtler tactics shaped by commercial and state actors. Algorithmic ranking often soft-censors content, while platform moderation and regulations designed to tackle online harms can unintentionally stifle dissenting voices. Meanwhile, the boundaries of what constitutes censorship, misinformation, or "fake news" in the West have become deeply politicized. Instead of outright bans, these dynamics often result in algorithmic manipulation, such as shadow bans that obscure certain media outlets or activist voices, downranking dissenting posts, or quietly removing apps under national security directives.

Crucially, these subtle methods often elude indices tracking global information freedom. By focusing on visible shutdowns and mass arrests, traditional indexes reinforce the binary view of an "open, democratic West" opposing an "authoritarian East." Yet the reality is far more complex. From China's state-engineered firewalls to the West's opaque algorithmic interventions, the result is often disturbingly similar: a narrowed space for critical discourse. As digital censorship evolves, so does resistance. This paper invites readers to move beyond simplistic binaries and examine how all states and cooperating platforms shape and constrain public exposure to ideas, voices, and debate.

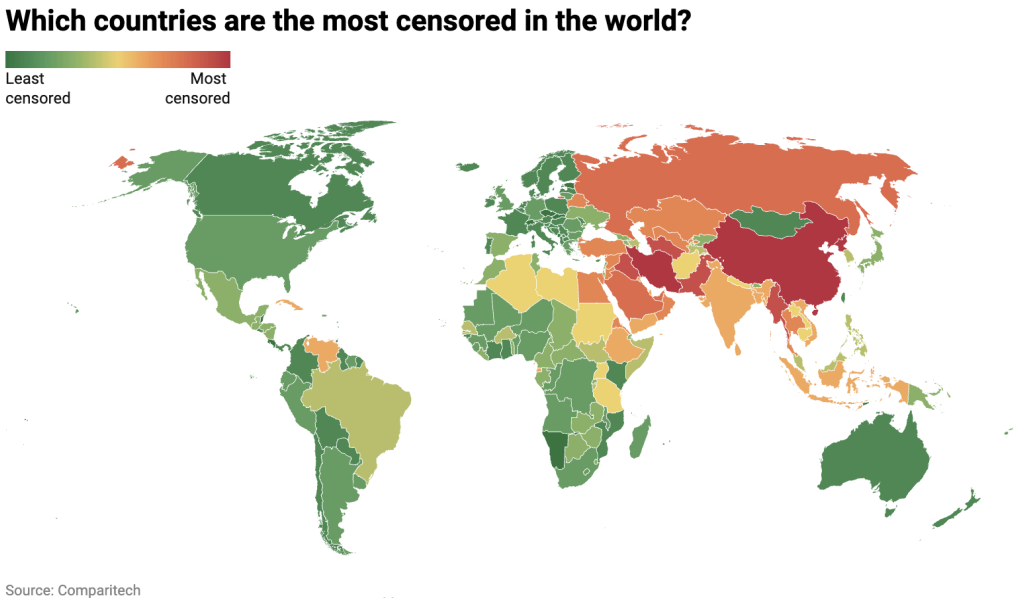
I. Introduction

In the early days of the internet, many scholars and policymakers believed that digital networks would dissolve borders and facilitate a global free flow of information, ultimately diminishing the power of state censorship and democratizing information. Cyber-libertarian thinkers imagined the web as a borderless realm where information transcends national boundaries and authoritarian constraints. By contrast, cyber-paternalist and -realist perspectives predicted that states and powerful private interests would find ways to control and manipulate this medium, just as they had done with traditional print and broadcast media. Over the past three decades, experience has vindicated the latter view: online censorship has not only persisted but evolved, adopting new forms and tools that differ substantially from traditional offline methods.

Traditional censorship often involved pre-publication reviews, book bans, newspaper shutdowns, physical intimidation, or the confiscation of printing presses. Today's digital censorship expands far beyond such overt and localized tactics. It leverages the unique characteristics of the internet – its speed, scale, global reach, and algorithmic sorting mechanisms – to enforce information control. State actors can now employ centralized "firewalls" and technical filtering systems to block entire swaths of the global web, as seen in models like China's "Great Firewall" and, more recently, Russia's internet sovereignty measures. Non-state actors, from extremist groups to corporate lobbyists, can exert more subtle forms of influence, shaping what users see through tactics like orchestrated disinformation campaigns or quiet pressures on platforms to de-rank specific topics. For example, between 2012 and 2019, Russian authorities blocked over 4.1 million Internet resources without a warrant, demonstrating how easily a state can shape digital access. Similarly, Turkey's 2017 ban on Wikipedia forced users seeking basic information to confront sudden, legally enforced barriers, underscoring how entire knowledge domains can be abruptly sealed off.

In recent years, as authoritarian-leaning states have refined their censorship playbooks, these methods have begun to diffuse internationally. Contemporary censorship no longer relies solely on brute force, such as mass arrests or wholesale newspaper shutdowns; it also emerges through elaborate surveillance infrastructures and subtle algorithmic tweaking. For instance, surveillance equipment from Chinese firms like Hikvision and Huawei now appears in dozens of countries worldwide, while Russia's SORM-compatible technology spreads quietly across former Soviet states and beyond. This global dispersal of information control techniques, ranging from keyword-based blocking to strategic downranking of dissenting voices, shows that censorship's frontier has become not only transnational but also deeply embedded in the political economies of technology export and influence.

Yet, this narrative overlooks the fact that Western democracies also engage in efforts to regulate misinformation and enhance platform accountability, crucial for addressing harms to democratic processes and marginalized groups. However, these initiatives raise questions about unintended impacts on free expression, challenging the simple dichotomy between a "free West" and an "authoritarian East." As recent debates about banning TikTok in the United States demonstrate, compliance and access to user data are not exclusively Eastern concerns. Western states also leverage economic and security arguments to influence platform behavior and potentially curb free expression online. In Western democracies, mechanisms of censorship have evolved to become more implicit and technologically driven. Germany's NetzDG law, introduced in 2018, exemplifies this shift. Designed to combat hate speech and illegal content on social media, NetzDG imposes strict deadlines for content removal and hefty fines for non-compliance. While intended to protect users from harmful content, critics argue that it incentivizes over-removal and stifles legitimate free expression, particularly of minority or dissenting voices.



A Simplistic Index Overlooking the Complexities of Soft Censorship

Algorithmic manipulation – such as shadow bans, curated feeds, and content downranking – has become a key form of censorship in democratic societies. Although framed as "quality control" or "user experience optimization," these covert interventions can systematically marginalize dissenting voices and critical content, especially when guided by government "requests" or policy signals from regulatory bodies. Moreover, the lack of transparency in algorithmic moderation means that citizens in liberal democracies may never know that their speech has been throttled or their posts buried, effectively creating hidden speech hierarchies that silently replicate authoritarian-style control.

Evolving nature of censorship in the digital age

Unlike traditional censorship, which could be blunt and easily identifiable, online censorship can be opaque and elusive. The globalized structure of the internet allows for diverse and layered interventions:

1. **Technical Censorship involves direct** interference with the underlying infrastructure. This includes DNS blocking, IP filtering, and the use of Deep Packet Inspection (DPI) to identify and halt traffic associated with politically or culturally sensitive content. While classical censorship involved physically seizing a newspaper print run, today's regimes can "pull a virtual plug" or slow traffic to certain regions, as observed in incidents where Russia, China, or Iran have regionally suspended mobile data service to quell unrest.
2. **Algorithmic and Platform-Level Controls:** Private companies running social media platforms, search engines, and app stores deploy moderation policies that determine what is visible, trending, or "recommended." Sometimes this is voluntary, as with corporate "community guidelines" that reflect corporate values and brand protection strategies. Other times, it results from state pressure – such as demanding that foreign technology companies comply with local laws on what can or cannot be posted – or from subtle market incentives that favor certain viewpoints. For instance, the Russian model relies on a combination of legal mandates and extralegal pressure on ISPs and platforms. Similarly, the Chinese case shows platforms employing armies of "content supervisors" or "50 cent party" commentators to shape discourse in line with state preferences. In Western contexts, algorithmic interference often operates more implicitly. For example, Facebook's decision to deprioritize political content in its News Feed in 2021 led to reduced visibility for both activist campaigns and independent media outlets, raising concerns about the platform's ability to quietly shape public discourse under the guise of content moderation.
3. **Self-Censorship and Behavioral Influence:** Unlike older systems where a citizen's silence might be forced by the tangible threat of arrest or violence, in the digital era users may voluntarily censor themselves due to the chilling effect of omnipresent surveillance, identity registration requirements, or platform moderation uncertainty. The breadth of hate speech, fake news, or "extremist" speech laws – such as Russia's legal provisions on "extremist materials" or China's ambiguous but strictly enforced guidelines on subversive content – creates an environment where users internalize restrictions. Similarly, in Western contexts, the fear of being shadow banned or having content algorithmically deprioritized for sharing non-mainstream, critical, or political voices can deter users from engaging in open discussions. This implicit form of censorship leads individuals to self-regulate their speech, avoiding controversial topics to maintain visibility and reach, effectively mirroring the suppressive effects seen in more overtly authoritarian regimes.

In the last decade, increasing global connectivity has paradoxically been accompanied by more sophisticated censorship tactics. Governments claim national security and cultural integrity justifications to expand their toolkit, while private platforms argue for content moderation as a way to combat disinformation or hate speech. The result is a highly complex environment where multiple actors – states, corporations, civil society groups – push and pull on the boundaries of permissible discourse.

Studying online censorship at this moment is crucial for several reasons. First, the growing convergence of digital communication technologies with every aspect of social, economic, and political life magnifies the impact of information controls. Second, as democracies struggle with the challenges of disinformation and extremist content, the lines between legitimate moderation and subtle censorship blur, making it imperative to understand the nuance of these interventions. Third, as networked authoritarian regimes perfect their techniques – sometimes exporting them or inspiring similar controls in other states – understanding these methods becomes essential to preserving an open global information environment.

The analytical framework developed in this report will consider censorship as a continuum. On one end lies "hard censorship," exemplified by total blackouts, banned websites, and criminal liability for accessing forbidden knowledge. On the other end, "soft censorship" includes algorithmic downranking of certain topics, shadow-banning of activists, and quiet removal of apps from stores at a government's request. Between these poles lie hybrid forms: content flagged as "extremist" and placed on public blacklists, forced data localization that encourages corporate compliance with local censorship laws, and platform policies that are continually adjusted in response to political pressure and market incentives.

The concept of censorship in the digital age cannot be divorced from its historical roots. The transition from analog to digital did not erase earlier strategies; it transformed them, making censorship cheaper, more flexible, and more easily concealed. Early internet governance scholarship noted that efforts like China's "Golden Shield" (Great Firewall) would serve as global precedents. Subsequent scholarship – on Russia's Internet laws, Europe's attempts to counter "fake news," and the U.S.' debates over platform liability – has shown that states and corporations alike adapt previous modes of influence into the digital domain for security and geopolitical interests. Thus, evolving definitions acknowledge that while censorship once required heavy-handed, resource-intensive action, today's methods exploit algorithmic curation, platform policies, and social norms to achieve similar ends with less visibility. While much scholarship focuses on the explicit censorship apparatuses in places like China and Russia, Western states increasingly rely on "soft" censorship tools, including algorithms that downrank certain content and disinformation laws that incentivize platforms to remove borderline material, effectively limiting the range of permissible speech without leaving overt legal footprints.

II. Drivers of online censorship

Political motivations

At the core of many censorship regimes are distinct political agendas. Authoritarian governments leverage online censorship to maintain power, quell dissent, and shape public perception. In China, the party-state's extensive firewall, coupled with a combination of overt (website blocking, keyword filtering) and subtle (algorithms that downrank politically sensitive content) tools, exemplifies a top-down approach to controlling the narrative. Russia, evolving more recently into a model of digital authoritarianism, employs a mixture of legislative mandates, public-private arrangements with ISPs, and co-optation of major platforms to achieve similar ends – preventing mobilization efforts like the Bolotnaya Square protests and deterring criticism of political leadership. An increasingly assertive digital authoritarianism has emerged from laws prosecuting hundreds for "extremist" online posts. 604 charges were brought between 2011 and 2017 under Articles 280 and 282, serving as a legal foundation for broad censorship.

These cases are not confined to a solely authoritarian axis. Some scholars highlight more subtle forms of political censorship in ostensibly democratic contexts. Western democracies and transitional states often use content moderation policies to combat extremist material or foreign disinformation, raising questions about transparency and due process. While these measures might be justified by national security or public safety concerns, they can also slide into politically opportunistic suppression of particular viewpoints. This tension is echoed by scholarship discussing global Internet governance institutions, showing that domestic politics shape how states respond to perceived digital threats. For instance,

electoral interference – in the form of blocking certain news sources or manipulating content circulation – occurs both in authoritarian and semi-competitive regimes, thereby confirming that political motivations for censorship transcend clear-cut categories.

Iran's online censorship framework offers another lens through which to understand political drivers. Like China and Russia, Iran heavily monitors and restricts content for national security purposes and regime stability. The state's approach includes blocking foreign platforms, imposing strict controls on messaging apps, and developing a state-sanctioned national intranet. Although Iran's motivations overlap with those of other authoritarian states – preventing online coordination of protests and suppressing dissident voices – its censorship paradigm is also influenced by religious and cultural factors that amplify the political calculus.

As these political agendas scale outward, we observe governments like Egypt or Tanzania, inspired by China's sophisticated firewall and Russia's legislative frameworks, adopting parallel regulations and technologies. For example, China's Belt and Road Initiative serves as a strategic conduit, allowing Beijing to export censorship know-how and surveillance kit – facial recognition systems, AI-enabled traffic management tools, and data localization mandates – directly to states willing to replicate aspects of its model. Similarly, Russia's reach through the Commonwealth of Independent States ensures that SORM-based monitoring and interception laws are mirrored in countries like Belarus, Kazakhstan, and Uzbekistan. This transnational replication confirms that censorship regimes often travel alongside economic partnerships and diplomatic ties, transforming political influence into a blueprint for controlling information beyond a single nation's borders.

In Western democracies, political motivations for censorship may cloak themselves in disinformation-countering strategies. Laws targeting "fake news" or "terrorist propaganda" risk creating an environment where political elites and well-connected actors can shape platform policies and push platforms to remove content that is politically inconvenient or challenging to dominant interests. This subtle form of content steering in the West is no less political than the more explicit blocking tactics observed in authoritarian states. It simply operates under a veneer of legality and corporate compliance, complicating the assumption that open societies inherently maintain truly free digital spaces.

Cultural, religious, and social factors

Cultural and religious norms often interact with political priorities to reinforce censorship. China's restrictions on religious or ethnically-oriented content – such as information related to Falun Gong or minority groups. Russia's legal provisions against "offending religious believers" similarly demonstrate that the line between cultural values and political enforcement is thin. Content deemed "extremist" can include religious satire, historical reinterpretations, or commentary on political leaders aligning with the national faith.

Iran provides a vivid example of how religious doctrine can underpin digital censorship. The country's Islamic Republic status informs its approach to online restrictions: content deemed contrary to Islamic moral standards or threatening to religious authority is systematically filtered out. Here, cultural preservation, religious legitimacy, and national identity are deeply intertwined. The blocking of websites promoting "un-Islamic" values or the suppression of content that offends religious sentiments blends the

cultural with the political, ensuring that censorship is not just top-down control, but also resonates with certain segments of the population's moral expectations. The government has repeatedly blocked messaging apps like Telegram and WhatsApp, citing moral and religious guidelines to justify silencing politically sensitive content, merging cultural norms with political imperatives. These apps, including Facebook, Instagram, X, and YouTube, have been completely blocked in recent years and are only accessible through VPNs. Ironically, millions of Iranians continue to use these platforms via VPNs, many of which are reportedly sold or tacitly permitted by the government, raising questions about potential behind-the-scenes collaborations or mutual interests in maintaining partial access.

The blending of cultural and religious imperatives with state censorship is not limited to any single region. Iran's "National Information Network," for instance, materialized partly through consulting with China, aligning Islamic principles with a tightly managed information sphere patterned on the Chinese model. In more secular contexts, like parts of Latin America, cultural values might manifest through narratives legitimizing surveillance under the guise of public safety. Here, Chinese-provided "safe city" solutions are installed to monitor crowds, identify "unruly" behavior, and thus quietly enforce norms, suggesting that where universal religious laws are absent, shared cultural or moral frameworks can still shape what content must vanish or be discouraged.

Beyond these explicitly authoritarian contexts, cultural and social pressures can also manifest in more open societies. Social media platforms themselves, spurred by user reports or media backlash, may remove content considered hateful or offensive. While such moderation can be well-intentioned, it also raises questions about cultural biases embedded in algorithmic decision-making and content reviewer guidelines.

Economic & corporate influences

Economic drivers also play a crucial role in shaping online censorship. Surveillance capitalism, where corporations monetize user data, enables subtle forms of censorship by tailoring content recommendations that maximize engagement and ad revenues, often at the expense of diverse or dissenting viewpoints. Many scholars highlight the interplay between corporate actors and state regulations: technology firms often comply with local censorship laws to maintain market access. In China, domestic companies like Tencent, Baidu, and Alibaba have long internalized censorship as part of their operational environment. International firms such as Google or Facebook have sometimes contemplated compromises – data localization, compliance with content takedowns – to enter lucrative markets. LinkedIn initially complied with Chinese rules by censoring profiles, including those of Western journalists, in 2021; however, mounting regulatory challenges and limited scope for operations led the platform to fully exit the Chinese market by August 2023, following the closure of its social networking features in 2021 and the eventual shutdown of its job-focused app, InCareer.

Russia's recent pushes for data localization laws and the blocking of platforms that refuse compliance similarly underline that economic incentives – access to large user bases and advertising revenues – can lead corporations to tailor their content policies in line with government demands. In democratic contexts, the necessity to comply with local regulations is equally compelling. For example, Brazil's nationwide ban on X (formerly Twitter) following its role in spreading political misinformation forced the platform to remove content or cease operations entirely, highlighting that companies cannot afford to defy state

mandates without significant repercussions, even in the West. Similarly, Telegram's founder Pavel Durov faced arrest in France after the platform cooperated with government requests to moderate content, illustrating that compliance pressures extend beyond authoritarian regimes.

Yet, economic incentives complicate the picture further. Chinese tech giants like ZTE and Alibaba and Russian firms like Protei and VAS Experts rely on foreign markets for growth. As they export not only hardware – such as CCTV cameras and DPI (Deep Packet Inspection) systems – but also consultancy and training, they expand their global footprint while normalizing more stringent content controls. Consider the digital forensics workshops arranged by China's Meiya Pico which has trained law enforcement from Argentina to Uzbekistan. These sessions highlight corporate-state synergy: governments receive advanced control tools and practical know-how, corporations secure lucrative deals and market influence, and the boundary between legitimate cybercrime policing and politically motivated suppression grows increasingly porous.

In sum, the political, cultural, and economic factors behind online censorship form a multi-dimensional matrix. Governments rely on censorship to safeguard regime legitimacy and neutralize opposition, while religious and cultural imperatives shape what is considered permissible speech. Economic incentives compel corporations to adapt their policies or risk losing market share, but censorship is not solely a tool of state power. Beyond regulatory compliance, purely commercial motivations also drive censorship practices. For instance, ISPs in Western countries may throttle foreign content or prioritize more profitable platforms not due to legal obligations but to reduce operational costs or favor lucrative partnerships. Additionally, platform-level decisions to shadow-ban certain media outlets or deprioritize specific content can stem from commercial interests aimed at maximizing user engagement and advertising revenues.

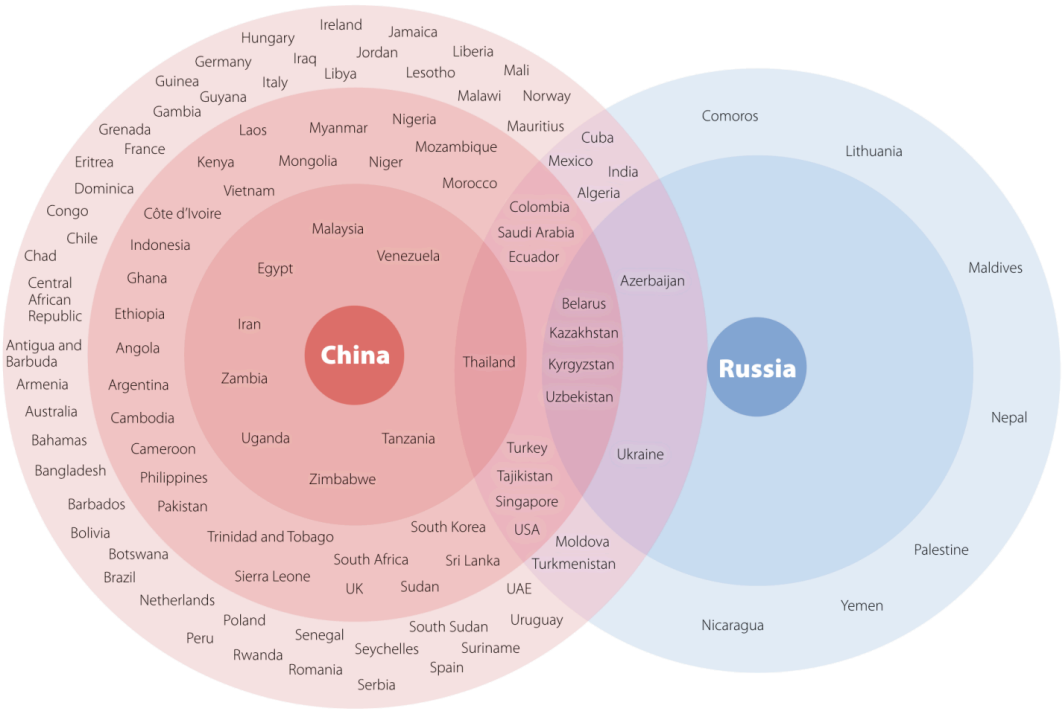
III. Key actors and their interactions

The ecosystem of online censorship is shaped by a web of interacting actors – ranging from governments and state security services to international technology giants, local ISPs, and grassroots organizations. These stakeholders do not operate in isolation; their relationships are dynamic, evolving in response to shifts in policy, technology, market forces, and user behavior. By examining their roles and the forms of censorship they employ, we gain a holistic understanding of how digital information flows are regulated, suppressed, or manipulated across different regimes and cultural contexts.

State-level actors

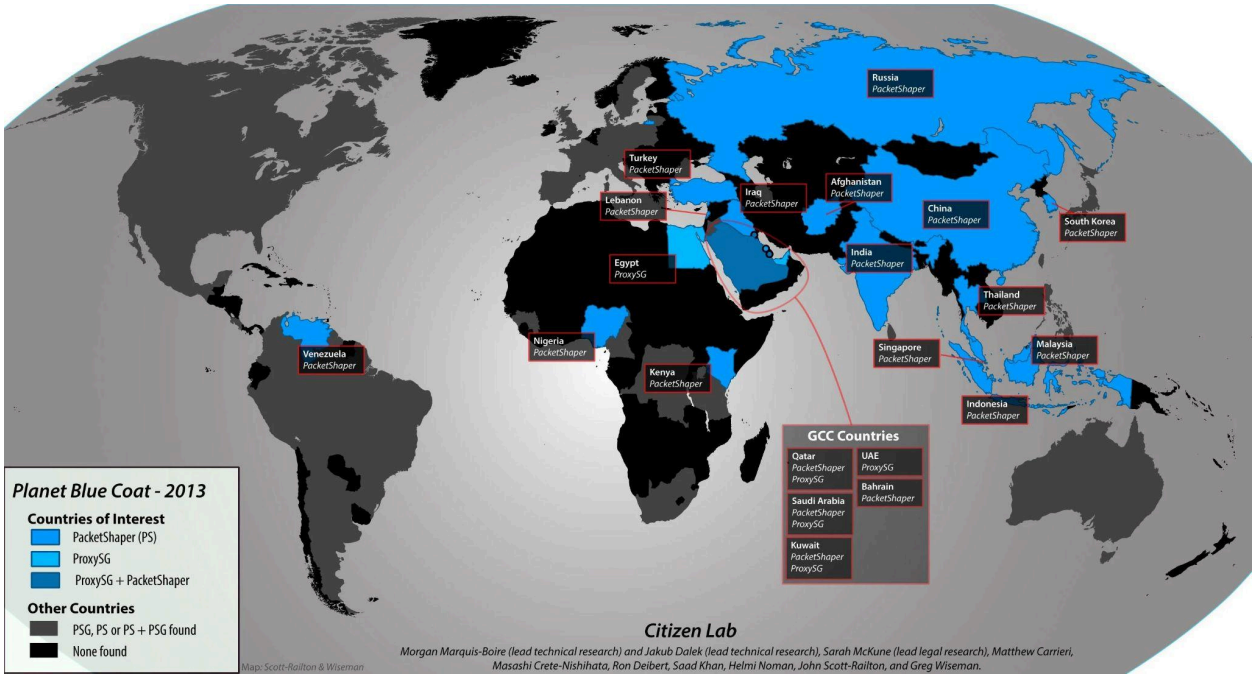
At the apex of most censorship architectures are state institutions – governments, regulatory bodies, and security agencies – who formulate and enforce legal and technical constraints. China's Cyberspace Administration of China (CAC) and Russia's Roskomnadzor provide clear illustrations of how centralized authorities impose top-down censorship mandates. In China, the CAC orchestrates a sophisticated model of "hard" censorship – direct blocking, keyword filtering, full-network isolation in critical moments – as well as "soft" censorship, such as algorithmic adjustments to search rankings or news feeds. Russia's Roskomnadzor, while historically less technologically centralized than the Chinese firewall system, has increasingly aimed to consolidate its control, implementing blacklists and data localization laws and testing isolation exercises to cut off the country's Internet infrastructure from the global web.

Concentric circles of influence. The inner circle represents the core, and the outer circles the periphery of respective technospheres.



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As Chinese and Russian systems of control travel abroad, the dynamic between local ISPs, platform providers, and government agencies intensifies. Countries along China's Belt and Road, for instance, may adopt local versions of China's vague cyber laws, encouraging ISPs to practice proactive filtering. Meanwhile, Russian-designed analytics suites – such as those sold by Analytical Business Solutions – help authorities in post-Soviet states swiftly identify perceived threats in social media chatter. Similarly, U.S.-made technologies have also been implicated in enabling censorship abroad. Companies like Cisco and Blue Coat Systems have reportedly sold network filtering and surveillance tools later used by governments in countries such as Saudi Arabia, Bahrain, and Syria to block content and monitor activists. This demonstrates that censorship-enabling technologies are not exclusive to authoritarian states like China and Russia but are also exported from democratic countries under the guise of commercial transactions.



US Surveillance and Censorship Tools Used Around the World

Non-state actors, including foreign journalists receiving training in Beijing's Baise Executive Leadership Academy, re-enter their home environments armed with insights that could reshape their editorial decisions. Simultaneously, activists and civil society groups face fresh challenges: not only must they learn about local constraints, but they must also navigate infrastructures and legal frameworks originally perfected in faraway states. In this interplay, censorship agendas and resistance strategies become transnational puzzles, each influenced by foreign templates and technologies.

Infrastructure & platform providers

Beyond the state, Internet Service Providers (ISPs), telecommunications firms, and global platform providers (social media networks, search engines, content delivery networks) function as key chokepoints. Technically, ISPs can enforce "hard" censorship by blocking domain names or IP addresses at the state's behest. Large telecom operators in Russia and Iran, often with partial state ownership or under strict licensing requirements, have limited room to resist such instructions. They must install surveillance and filtering equipment, as seen with Russia's SORM or Iran's state-controlled network infrastructure.

Throttling by ISPs often serves not only regulatory or political objectives but also economic motivations, where commercial savings and network efficiency take precedence. ISPs deliberately slow down foreign or high-bandwidth content, such as streaming platforms or international data-heavy services, to reduce operational costs and manage congestion. This practice frequently prioritizes domestic or partnered platforms through mechanisms like zero-rating deals where selected services do not count against data caps, subtly steering users toward favored content. For example, video streaming services or cloud-based applications might face slower speeds during peak usage times, while local alternatives or platforms with exclusive ISP agreements perform seamlessly. Such practices, though framed as fair bandwidth

management or congestion control, introduce a commercially-driven layer of censorship that influences user access to diverse global content, often mirroring more explicit control seen in authoritarian contexts.

Meanwhile, major platforms – Facebook (Meta), Twitter (X), Google, TikTok, and WeChat – act as gatekeepers of information flow. These platforms implement their own policies on content moderation, which can lead to "soft" censorship. For example, algorithmic filtering may disproportionately downrank political dissent or favor state-aligned narratives, whether deliberately or as an unintended outcome of opaque recommendation engines. In authoritarian markets, these companies face stark choices: comply with censorship demands for market access or withdraw services altogether. There have been discussions on how Google weighed entering the Chinese market under the "Dragonfly" project or how LinkedIn accepted localized censorship rules to operate in China, illustrating the influence governments wield over global platforms. Similarly, Russia's Telegram blocking attempts underscore how states pressure messaging and social media services to grant access to user data or adhere to content removal requests. Infrastructure providers and platforms, from major ISPs to Apple's App Store, sometimes comply with censorship demands – like Apple removing dozens of VPN apps from its Chinese App Store in 2017 and in Russia in September 2024 – showing how global corporations become enablers of local censorship regimes.

However, platforms are not always passive. Some choose limited pushback or transparency measures – e.g., Twitter's past public "transparency reports" on takedown requests – offering partial resistance. When corporate self-interest aligns with free expression or brand reputation, platforms might refuse compliance or relocate services. The tension between platforms and governments thus becomes a negotiation shaped by economic incentives, public opinion, and reputational costs.

Non-state and transnational actors

Non-state actors also shape the censorship landscape. On the one hand, civil society groups, NGOs, and advocacy organizations – such as those producing indices like Freedom House or working on open-source testing (e.g., OONI) – fight censorship by documenting, monitoring, and exposing hidden content removal (criticism to follow in Section V). They assist users with circumvention tools, pressuring platforms and states toward greater accountability and less arbitrary enforcement. Their influence is global and networked, helping to raise awareness of censorship in places like Russia, China, and Iran, as well as highlighting subtler censorship forms in democracies.

On the other hand, extremist organizations, "troll farms," and disinformation networks complicate the picture. Far from simply being victims of censorship, these groups also benefit from information manipulation. Russian "troll farms" and disinformation agents exploit platforms' moderation challenges, forcing states and tech companies to overcorrect and potentially censor legitimate discourse. In these instances, non-state actors provoke an environment where governments justify more authoritarian measures. Similarly, extremist content online leads to calls from activist groups and the public to remove hateful or harmful speech, giving platforms and states a moral rationale for censorship – though this can create a slippery slope.

Additionally, some lobbyists, industry coalitions, or professional associations influence how moderation policies develop. By lobbying for stricter or looser regulations, they can tilt the balance between free

expression and censorship. In certain cultural contexts, religious institutions or community leaders exert pressure on platforms and ISPs to remove “offensive” cultural or religious content. These actors represent the diverse tapestry of interest groups that can collectively push censorship norms in different directions – sometimes aligning with state objectives, other times opposing them.

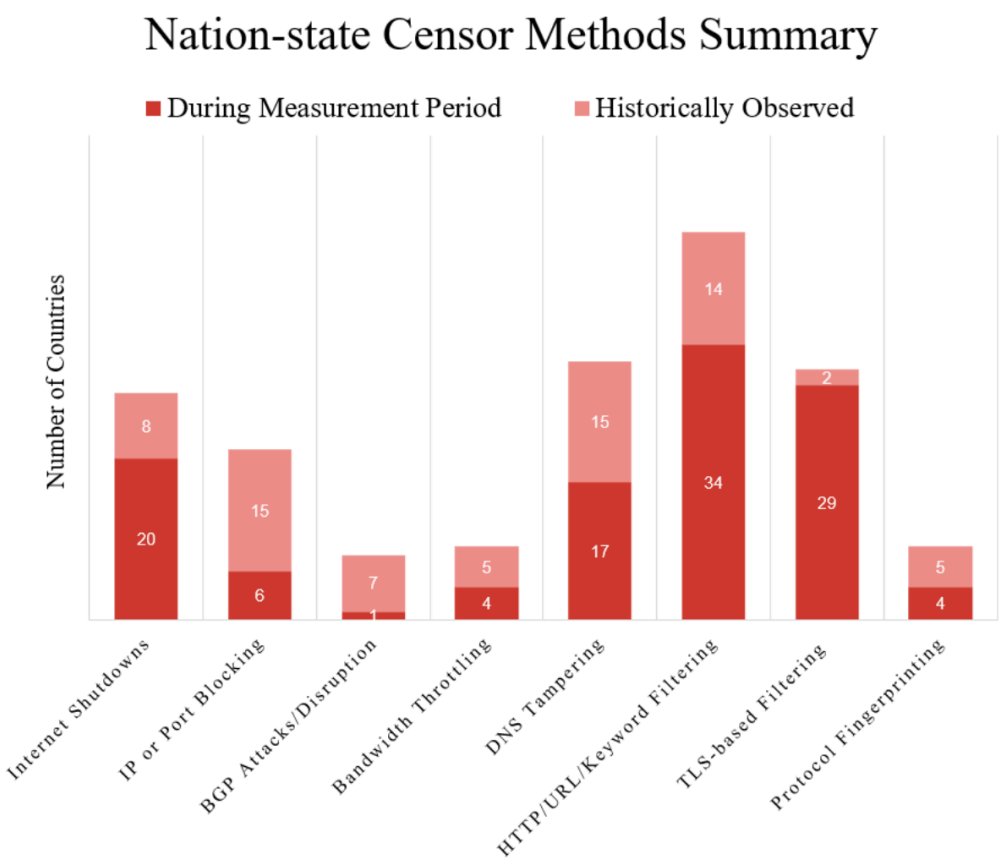
IV. Techniques and mechanisms of online censorship

Online censorship employs a diverse toolkit of technical and policy-based methods. Some approaches are overt, such as domain-level blocks or firewalls that users can easily detect. Others are more subtle – algorithmic adjustments to content ranking systems or quiet requests for certain posts to be taken down. Understanding these mechanisms is crucial because their sophistication and opacity often make it challenging to assess how, when, and why certain content disappears or becomes harder to find. Moreover, as censorship evolves alongside technology, states and platforms continually innovate, deploying new solutions to tighten information control or circumvent existing blocks.

Direct technical controls

The most visible and traditional forms of online censorship rely on direct technical intervention at the network or infrastructure level. China’s “Great Firewall” exemplifies this approach, blending DNS tampering, IP blocking, keyword filtering, and Deep Packet Inspection (DPI) technology. These tools enable Chinese authorities to inspect the contents of data packets and block or throttle traffic containing proscribed terms or domains. Such measures effectively create a “walled garden” where users remain confined to a filtered version of the global Internet. China’s firewall blocks foreign social media giants like Facebook and Twitter, and its censorship apparatus can target up to 100,000 posts per day with the help of automated scanners and human censors.

Russia has also advanced its censorship capabilities, increasingly relying on DPI and network isolation laws. Originally less centralized than China’s system, Russian authorities now require ISPs to install DPI equipment and enforce blacklists maintained by Roskomnadzor. Periodic tests of “RuNet” isolation and mandates for local data storage further expand the government’s capacity to block or restrict sites and services. Iran’s “National Information Network” employs similar strategies, including keyword-based blocking and regional slowdowns or outages during politically sensitive moments, demonstrating how these tools are often deployed during elections, protests, or other crises to suppress dissent.



Nation-state censor methods summary

Source: Alexander Master's Dissertation

However, direct technical controls are not limited to authoritarian states. Western democracies also utilize these tools, albeit on a narrower scale and often under the guise of legal compliance or national security. In the UK, the Online Safety Act empowers regulators, such as Ofcom, to enforce a broad range of safety measures aimed at protecting users – particularly children – from harmful or illegal content. This includes the authority to require ISPs to limit or block access to services that fail to comply with mandated safety standards. For instance, platforms hosting illegal content, such as child exploitation material, or those deemed to facilitate hate speech, harassment, or terrorism, may face legal demands to restrict access or implement stringent content moderation systems. Non-compliance could result in significant penalties, such as fines of up to £18 million or 10% of global revenue, and, in severe cases, ISPs may be directed to disrupt access entirely through "business disruption measures."

This regulatory framework adds a layer of control at the infrastructure level. ISPs could be compelled to block non-compliant platforms, effectively introducing site-level restrictions akin to censorship mechanisms in more authoritarian contexts. While these measures are framed as safeguarding public interest, they carry potential risks for freedom of expression and access to information, especially when criteria for "harmful" content are vague or inconsistently applied.

Similarly, traffic shaping – a method by which ISPs intentionally slow or delay access to certain websites – has been employed in Western countries, including the UK, to prioritize domestic platforms or manage network congestion. High-bandwidth activities, such as peer-to-peer file-sharing or streaming from foreign platforms, are often deprioritized, creating an uneven playing field for online content. This practice, while motivated by network management or commercial concerns, effectively limits users' access to certain types of content or services. For example, streaming platforms competing with local broadcasters or social media apps requiring substantial bandwidth may experience slower loading speeds, subtly discouraging their use.

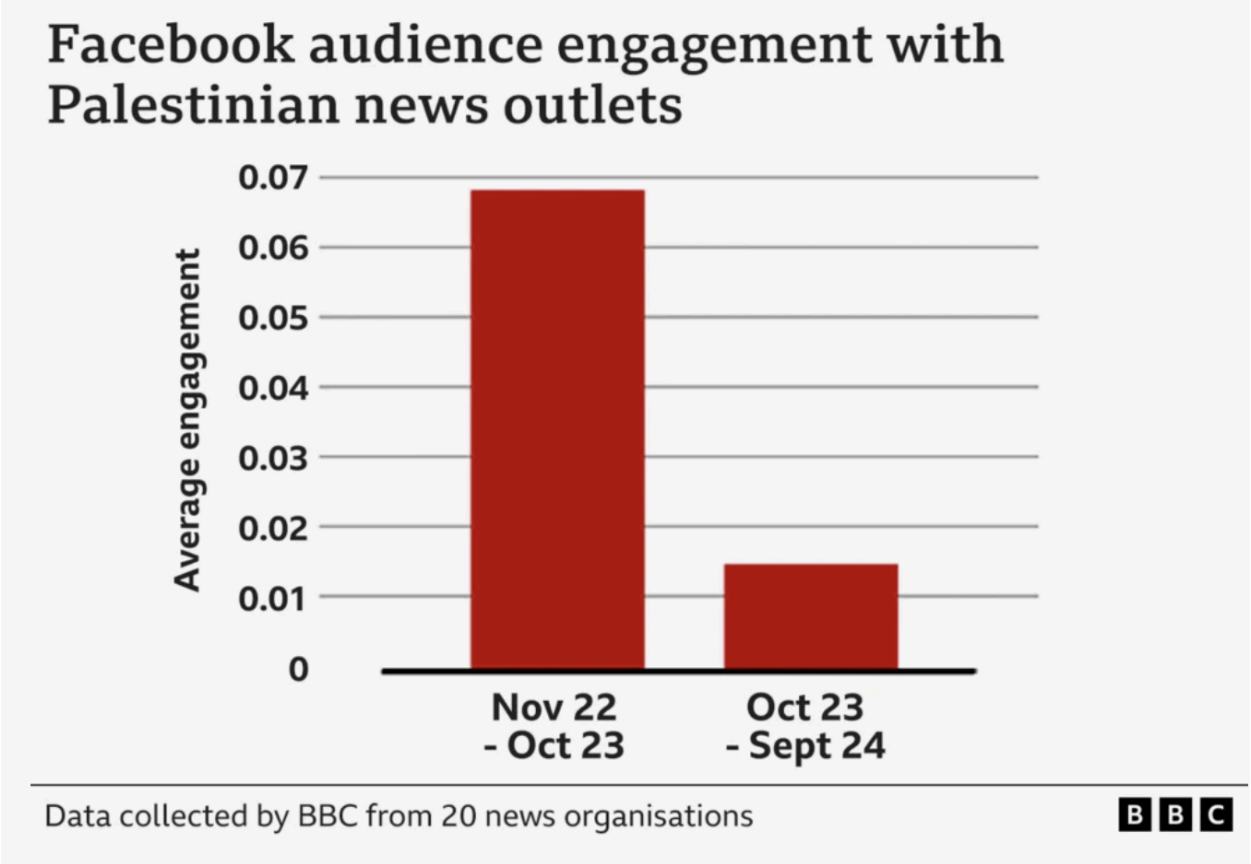
These practices, while often less visible or dramatic than their counterparts in China or Russia, reveal how direct technical controls are employed globally to shape online behavior. Whether through overt state mandates or commercial arrangements, such interventions underscore the ubiquity of infrastructure-level censorship in maintaining the integrity of various national policies and commercial priorities.

Platform-level moderation and algorithmic biases

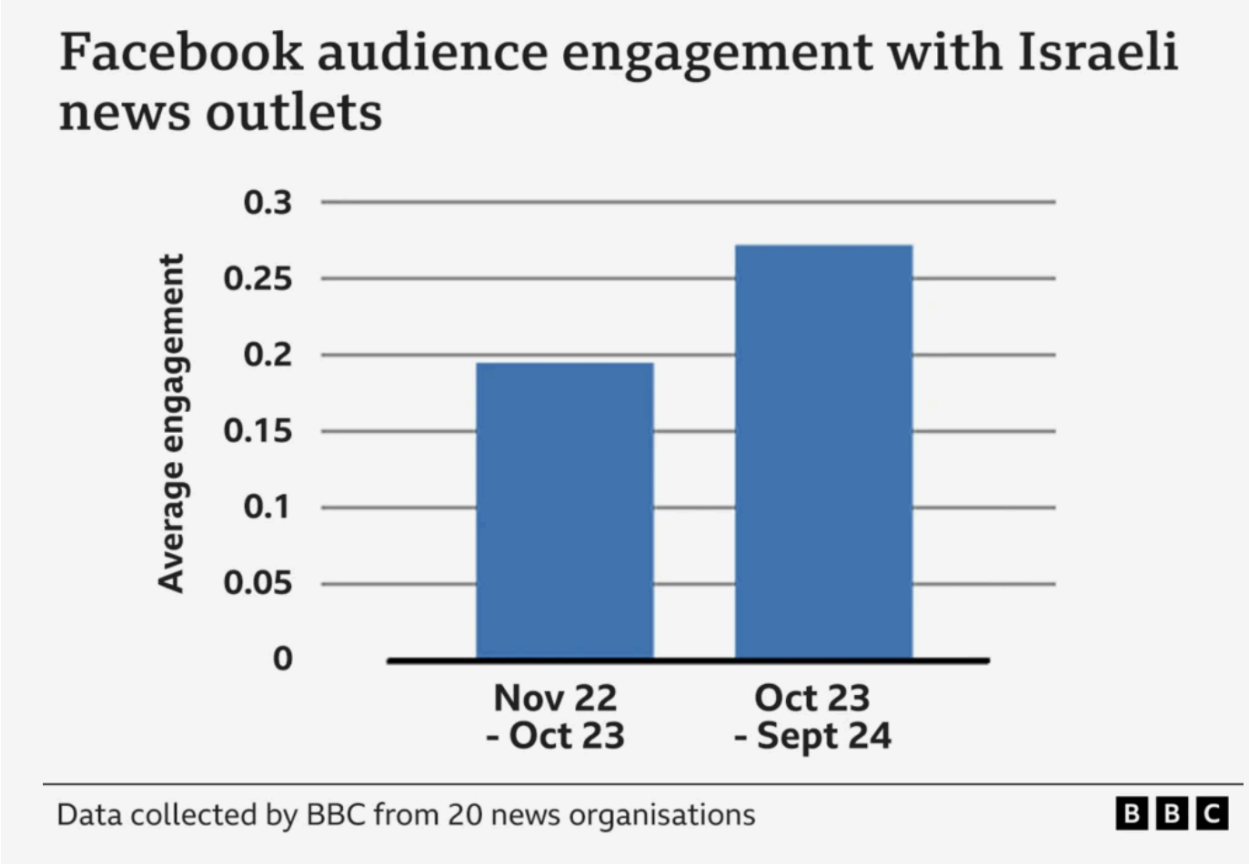
As user experiences are increasingly mediated through centralized platforms – social media networks, search engines, and messaging apps – censorship often occurs at the content layer. Instead of blocking entire domains, states or corporations can push platforms to remove or downrank specific content, resulting in a more opaque form of censorship. For example, in China, platforms employ tens of thousands of content supervisors to align discourse with state preferences, while in Western contexts, algorithmic downranking or YouTube's "restricted mode" can quietly marginalize controversial topics. Shadow-banning – where posts are demoted or hidden without user awareness – exemplifies how content can be functionally silenced without overt bans. Automated moderation systems, driven by AI, further complicate the landscape, as they may over-remove content, inadvertently silencing legitimate debates or minority voices due to cultural or political biases embedded in training data.

In nominally democratic societies or hybrid regimes, state control often operates through indirect mechanisms. Governments in the European Union or the United States often collaborate with platforms to remove "extremist content" or address harmful misinformation. While these efforts are vital for mitigating real threats, they may inadvertently suppress dissenting viewpoints if transparency and due process are lacking. These measures, while less overt than the Chinese or Russian approaches, still risk suppressing dissenting viewpoints, particularly when transparency and due process are lacking.

Economic motivations further amplify these dynamics. Big Tech platforms, driven by profit motives, design algorithms and moderation policies that prioritize user engagement, minimize legal risks, and protect their brands. This leads to forms of "soft" censorship, such as shadow bans, demonetization, or selective de-ranking of content deemed controversial or unprofitable. The political economy of censorship in democracies thus becomes a complex interplay of state pressure, public scrutiny, and corporate self-regulation. For example, recent shadow bans on Meta users posting about Palestine demonstrate how platforms' actions can echo authoritarian-style suppression under the guise of maintaining community standards or reducing legal exposure.



In countries in the Global South or those undergoing political transitions, censorship practices are often more fluid and reactive. Temporary internet shutdowns during protests, throttling bandwidth during elections, or arresting bloggers under vaguely defined laws illustrate ad-hoc measures frequently employed in politically turbulent environments. India, for instance, resorted to over 100 internet shutdowns in a single year to quell unrest, demonstrating how temporary disruptions can become de facto censorship tools.



Platforms operating in these regions face unique pressures to align with local cultural and religious norms. They may be compelled to remove content deemed blasphemous or politically sensitive, or negotiate data localization and content guidelines on a case-by-case basis. In such contexts, multinational tech companies often defer to local laws or cultural expectations to maintain market access, while local ISPs, lacking political leverage, comply with government directives without resistance. Users are caught in a dynamic tug-of-war between state control, corporate interests, and local activism.

On a global scale, censorship frameworks migrate along geopolitical pathways. China's Belt and Road Initiative exports its comprehensive surveillance and platform alignment models to Africa, Central Asia, and parts of Eastern Europe. Russia's influence, though regionally concentrated in the CIS, extends as far as Latin America, where tools like Russian audio forensics are adopted in countries like Mexico. These exported models exemplify how censorship practices are no longer confined by geography, embedding themselves in political, economic, and cultural networks worldwide.

Whether through search result manipulations, shadow bans, or direct takedown requests, platforms increasingly act as gatekeepers of discourse. Their algorithms and moderation policies, shaped by state pressure, legal concerns, and commercial interests, dictate the visibility and accessibility of content. This subtle interplay between state and corporate agendas underscores how even democracies contribute to a global ecosystem of censorship, one that is often invisible in dominant indices portraying the West as bastions of net neutrality and free expression.

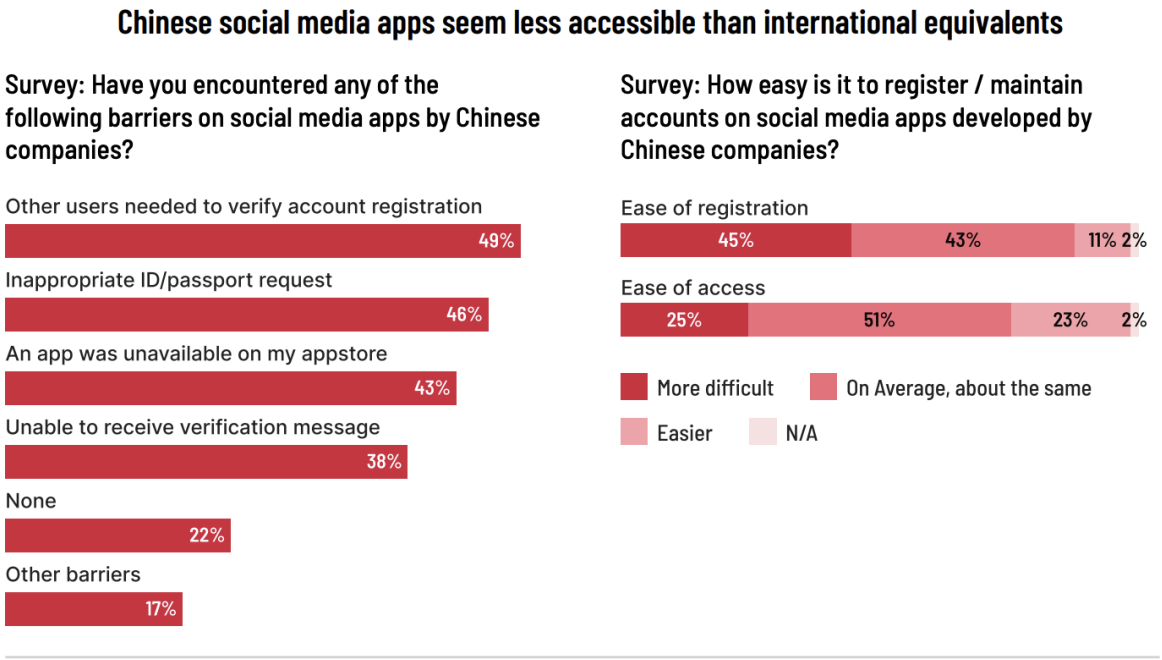
Emerging censorship technologies

The censorship arms race is ongoing. New technologies – such as AI-enhanced surveillance tools – promise more precise and comprehensive filtering. Governments may use machine learning to identify patterns of subversive speech, while platforms deploy AI to detect and remove harmful content at scale. Yet these same tools can be repurposed, blurring lines between acceptable moderation and politically motivated suppression.

On the other side, blockchain-based protocols and decentralized architectures challenge the feasibility of large-scale censorship. Content hosted via peer-to-peer networks or on censorship-resistant platforms can evade conventional DNS-level blocks. States respond by strengthening traffic analysis methods, pressuring app stores to remove circumvention tools (e.g., VPNs or privacy-focused applications), and possibly exploring quantum-resistant cryptographic interception strategies.

Often, these techniques and mechanisms are layered. For instance, during politically sensitive events, a government might simultaneously deploy network-level throttling, send legal notices to platforms demanding content removal, and rely on AI moderation tools controlled or influenced by local intermediaries. Companies facing contradictory legal regimes—strict censorship rules at home, freer speech norms abroad – must craft complex solutions, sometimes geofencing content or applying "differential enforcement," where a video or article remains visible in one country but is blocked in another.

This interplay of hard (direct, infrastructural) and soft (algorithmic, policy-driven) methods creates an environment in which users struggle to discern the forces behind content suppression. Consequently, trust in platforms and information ecosystems erodes. Activists and journalists may self-censor, anticipating punitive responses before posting sensitive material, thereby making censorship partially self-enforcing. In addition, many governments now require real-name registration for online accounts, ensuring that every post or search query can be traced back to a specific individual. By making anonymity more difficult, these identity verification mandates heighten the stakes of speaking out, reinforce self-censorship, and integrate with surveillance tools to streamline the enforcement of censorship laws. The subtlety of some measures also allows states and companies to deflect blame, framing takedowns or visibility reductions as mere "terms of service" enforcement or benign quality control.



Source: Anonymous survey amongst 65 members of the at-risk community (conducted March 2024).

Challenging the Global North vs. Global South binary

While it might be tempting to assume that censorship is more pervasive or draconian in the Global South and more refined or limited in the Global North, many scholars caution against such simplistic binaries. Liberal democracies can still enable censorship through corporate-run filters or overly broad hate speech regulations. Conversely, some Global South countries might foster more open information ecosystems due to less technical capacity or stronger reliance on foreign platforms that are less easily controlled.

Likewise, trade-offs vary: A state may justify censorship for "national security," a tech platform may claim it's filtering "misinformation" in the name of social responsibility, and both could be influenced by cultural expectations for decorum or morality. Corporate compliance or resistance is context-dependent. Some firms take a hard stand, refusing to bend to certain censorious regimes, while others quietly comply, citing profit motives and shareholder interests.

Recommendation algorithms, language filters, and automated moderation tools initially developed for one environment may be repurposed or misapplied in another. Corporate ethics policies, profit motives, and supply chain dependencies intersect with local regulatory frameworks. Over time, these global corporate practices influence local discourse in subtle ways, potentially aligning even disparate regions under a convergent censorship logic – one that blends political, cultural, and commercial interests.

Ultimately, what emerges from a comparative view is that censorship is not monolithic. It does not easily split into "authoritarian" vs. "democratic," "North" vs. "South." Instead, it is best understood as an ecosystem of competing pressures: states wishing to protect their narrative and authority, platforms navigating global markets and diverse legal systems, and users caught in a crossfire of policies,

algorithms, and cultural mores. From China's highly centralized, advanced infrastructural model to the more fragmented, market-driven censorship in liberal democracies and onto the hybrid or transitional states where ad-hoc and unpredictable interventions prevail, the global picture defies simple categories. Each context presents unique trade-offs and aligns censorship practices along different axes of power – some privileging national sovereignty, others corporate discretion, and still others local cultural consensus.

In all cases, the political economy framework helps to highlight that censorship is always about trade-offs – between security and freedom, profit and principle, compliance and resistance – and that the distribution of power among states, corporations, and civil society determines the shape and outcome of online information control across regions.

V. Measuring censorship and identifying blind spots

Efforts to systematically measure online censorship have produced a range of indices, reports, and technical measurement tools, such as those developed by Freedom House, Reporters Without Borders (RSF), and the Open Observatory of Network Interference (OONI). These resources aim to quantify and compare censorship practices across countries and platforms, providing valuable data for policymakers, advocates, researchers, and the general public. However, the task of accurately capturing the full spectrum of online censorship is fraught with methodological challenges and significant blind spots.

Prominent indices like Freedom House's "Freedom on the Net" or RSF's "World Press Freedom Index" tend to emphasize government-imposed restrictions, legal frameworks, and cases of direct, visible censorship (e.g., blocking of news sites and bloggers). These metrics are particularly strong at cataloging overt government actions: new legislation that limits online speech, spikes in blocklists that correspond to political events, or explicit harassment of journalists and activists. Similarly, technical measurement projects such as OONI focus on detecting network interference – monitoring DNS manipulation, TCP/IP packet injections, or HTTP status anomalies that indicate site blocking.

While these approaches provide a robust baseline for understanding where and when certain types of censorship occur, they are less equipped to capture subtler forms of digital information control. Index-based rankings can inadvertently privilege what is easily observable – like IP address blocking – over less tangible, more complex phenomena.

One major blind spot relates to "soft" censorship by platforms or algorithms. Unlike a firewall that outright prevents users from accessing a website, algorithmic throttling or shadow banning in so-called democratic states often leaves no clear digital footprint. Users might see fewer posts from certain accounts, or content might slowly drift out of recommended feeds without any transparent explanation. Researchers attempting to measure such occurrences face difficulties in isolating cause and effect, especially when corporate policies and proprietary algorithms are opaque.

Studies highlight how the current assessment frameworks often under-represent or fail to account for corporate-driven censorship. Because many global platforms are private companies with their own terms of service, moderation guidelines, and internal algorithms, they can shape user experiences in ways that mimic state-imposed censorship but remain undocumented by conventional indices. Existing metrics

usually focus on state-level repression, not the economic and reputational pressures that lead platforms to remove content or downrank information. As a result, the narrative promoted by these indices inadvertently perpetuates a simplistic East/West divide, masking the fact that Western models of content governance – though cloaked in democratic rhetoric – can also restrict information diversity and stifle minority voices.

Cultural nuances and linguistic barriers

Another limitation stems from cultural and linguistic complexity. Censorship indicators developed for English-language platforms and Western legal norms may struggle to detect culturally specific forms of suppression. For instance, religiously motivated content bans or content filtered due to local moral codes may not register on a standard index if the methodology focuses only on political speech. Likewise, automated tools scanning for censorship might miss subtle language cues or slang terms that signal self-censorship or community-driven norms in non-Western languages. In parts of the Middle East, coded references to political figures or events – slang or metaphors – can slip past automated detection, leaving indexes blind to state-influenced whisper networks that discourage open criticism.

Studies suggest that this cultural specificity creates a measurement gap: researchers may fail to appreciate the full impact of censorship in regions where enforcement is informal, community-based, or sensitive to context. Language barriers also inhibit effective data collection: if measurement tools and surveys are not adapted to local languages and platforms, the analysis may skew heavily toward regions where English-language data is readily available.

A recurring theme in the literature is the problem of data accessibility. Some states work diligently to conceal their censorship tactics, employing techniques that are harder to detect. For example, throttling bandwidth during protests may appear as mere “network congestion,” making it difficult for measurement tools to prove intentional interference. Meanwhile, in more transparent or open societies, evidence of censorship (or its absence) is easier to collect, potentially painting a distorted comparative picture that underestimates the subtlety of control in more repressive environments.

The reliance on external reporting and user-submitted evidence can introduce biases. Certain advocacy groups or NGOs may focus on particular types of censorship that align with their mission, overlooking other forms. A lack of local partners or field researchers in some regions can produce patchy coverage. As a result, the global indices might overemphasize states where evidence is plentiful while neglecting situations where censorship is hidden behind more intricate socio-technical arrangements.

Proposed improvements and methodological innovations

To address these blind spots, various thinkers propose expanding the toolkit for measuring censorship:

1. **Holistic Indicators:** Develop metrics that track not only blocked domains and arrests but also signs of algorithmic manipulation, patterns in content removal requests, and shifts in platform policies. Incorporating user surveys, ethnographic studies, and leaked moderation guidelines could enrich quantitative indices.

2. **Greater Transparency from Platforms:** Encourage or require major tech companies to share more detailed data on content takedowns, geoblocking, and algorithmic downranking. Transparency reports, if standardized and audited by independent bodies, could help indices include corporate practices in their assessments.
3. **Localized and Context-Aware Approaches:** Invest in region-specific research initiatives that understand local languages, norms, and customs. Partnering with local NGOs and academics can yield more nuanced data collection methods that respect cultural differences and detect forms of censorship invisible to standardized, globally uniform indicators.
4. **Mixed-Methods Research:** Combine automated network measurement tools with qualitative interviews, on-the-ground reporting, and analysis of internal corporate documents. By triangulating multiple data sources, researchers can get closer to understanding the full spectrum of suppression, from overt government crackdowns to subtle platform-driven constraints.
5. **Longitudinal Studies:** Instead of one-off annual reports, longer-term monitoring, and time-series analyses can reveal trends in censorship techniques and highlight emerging patterns of suppression. Over time, this approach might detect shifts from overt to covert methods or from state-led to corporate-driven censorship.

Improved measurement will require recognizing censorship as a multifaceted, evolving practice. Effective indices should not assume that all censorship can be counted, such as blocked websites or arrested journalists. For example, while OONI network measurements can detect the presence of Huawei middleboxes performing DPI in Colombia, Pakistan, or Spain, these tests cannot easily reveal whether the equipment's configuration is shaped by a foreign government's blueprint. Similarly, metrics from Freedom House or RSF may note a spike in arrests of bloggers or blocked websites, but they rarely capture the subtler, corporate-driven suppression exported through foreign journalism workshops or technology training. Overcoming these blind spots requires researchers to combine network analysis with ethnographic fieldwork, multilingual surveys, leaked moderation rules, and a deep understanding of platform supply chains. Without these refinements, much of the transnational diffusion of censorship tools and tactics – especially those promoted under the guise of "security improvements" or "media development" – will remain hidden.

VI. Resistance, circumvention, and adaptation

Despite the intensity and sophistication of online censorship regimes, users, activists, and civil society groups across the globe have consistently found ways to circumvent restrictions and reclaim their agency in digital spaces. The existing literature stresses that online information control is not a static, one-sided affair but rather a dynamic ecosystem where each new censorship technique eventually encounters a corresponding workaround. This "cat-and-mouse" dynamic underscores the resilience of user communities and the importance of technological innovation, grassroots mobilization, and digital literacy in pushing back against information control.

Technical workarounds and circumvention tools

One of the most visible forms of resistance arises from the development and widespread adoption of technical circumvention tools. Virtual Private Networks (VPNs), for example, allow users to route their

traffic through servers located in more open internet jurisdictions, effectively bypassing local firewalls and IP-based blocks. Proxies and encrypted messaging platforms like Signal further enable secure communication channels that are less vulnerable to surveillance and tampering. Tor, a well-known anonymizing network, masks user identities and protects them from certain forms of traffic analysis, making it more difficult for censors to target specific individuals or content sources.

Beyond these established solutions, newer tools and decentralized protocols are emerging. InterPlanetary File System (IPFS) provides a distributed method of storing and retrieving information, making it harder for any single authority to block or remove specific content. Similarly, projects like Nym add an extra layer of privacy and anonymity by using mixnets, which route data through multiple nodes to obfuscate patterns of communication. By resisting centralized points of control, these technologies challenge the fundamental architecture on which most censorship practices rely.

The evolving nature of technical workarounds is evident in how communities respond to state-level interventions. For example, when governments attempt to crack down on VPN usage through deep packet inspection or VPN signature detection, developers of circumvention tools respond by employing “stealth” protocols or integrating more advanced obfuscation techniques. This iterative process mirrors an arms race: each new censorship tactic sparks a corresponding refinement in anti-censorship technology.

The availability and effectiveness of technological tools alone are not sufficient. Studies emphasize the importance of user agency, community resilience, and grassroots innovation. Local groups, digital rights NGOs, and volunteer collectives often produce and distribute guides – sometimes in multiple languages – on how to set up and maintain secure communications, use circumvention tools effectively, and recognize signs of manipulation in online information. In regions experiencing severe repression, activists might create community mesh networks: localized communication infrastructures that bypass state-controlled ISPs altogether. Such grassroots initiatives highlight that technical literacy and awareness are key components of resistance. For example, In Iran, activists have experimented with mesh networks like Bluetooth-based applications and local Wi-Fi sharing to distribute protest videos and guides to secure messaging, bypassing state-filtered ISPs entirely. Moreover, just as the Russian government tested RuNet isolation exercises in 2019, users responded by updating VPN protocols and circulating fresh IP addresses on encrypted chats, transforming each crackdown into a rallying point for technical ingenuity.

Crowdsourcing knowledge about censorship circumvention is also common. Online forums, social media groups, and diaspora communities regularly share updated lists of unblocked proxies, fresh VPN server addresses, or alternative URLs that mirror censored content. When digital rights organizations run workshops or create helplines where users can learn about anti-censorship solutions, they foster a culture of digital self-defense. This user-to-user knowledge transfer ensures that even as states attempt to clamp down on technical countermeasures, new cohorts of users gain the know-how to navigate controlled spaces.

The landscape of censorship and its resistance is a perpetual arms race. States and platforms evolve their methods, deploying more sophisticated AI-based takedowns, stronger encryption-breaking capabilities, and even proactive blocking measures against known circumvention protocols. In response, tool developers experiment with novel approaches: implementing domain fronting (where traffic is disguised

as if coming from popular CDNs), leveraging blockchain-based content storage, or employing AI to guess and adapt to new filtering patterns in real time.

While high-tech tools and complex protocols often dominate discussions on anti-censorship efforts, critics remind us that the human dimension remains central. Without trust, communities of practice, and widespread digital literacy, even the most sophisticated circumvention tools will fail to achieve their potential. Digital literacy campaigns, “how-to” guides, and easily accessible educational resources help ensure that lay users – who may not be tech experts – still have ways to safeguard their access to information. When teachers, journalists, students, and everyday citizens understand basic operational security, encryption usage, and the logic behind decentralized networks, they become more resilient to various forms of online repression.

A multi-layered approach is crucial here: combining political advocacy that demands transparency and accountability from platforms and governments, technological development that outpaces censorious innovation, and community-level education that empowers everyday users. Together, these efforts help create an environment where censorship is never unchallenged and where new barriers to free expression are continually tested and undermined by informed, tech-savvy, and organized communities. This landscape of resistance and adaptation ensures that online censorship is neither inevitable nor absolute. Instead, it becomes a series of tactical moves and counter-moves where ingenuity, collaboration, and resilience can preserve spaces for free expression, open communication, and the continued exchange of ideas.

VII. Conclusion & future directions

The landscape of online censorship is a complex and evolving assemblage of power, technology, and policy, shaped by political, economic, and cultural forces across the globe. While China’s Great Firewall, Russia’s “Internet sovereignty,” and Iran’s National Information Network exemplify overt, state-managed models of censorship, this paper demonstrates that information control is not confined to autocracies. In democratic contexts, market-driven content moderation and algorithmic biases, shadow-banning, and opaque content moderation shape public discourse with the critical aim of combating extremism, misinformation, and hate speech. These efforts highlight the challenge of balancing information control with transparency and accountability.

A key takeaway is the convergence of technical sophistication across regimes. Tools like deep packet inspection and algorithmic suppression, once hallmarks of authoritarian states, are increasingly adopted in democracies, raising questions about transparency and accountability. At the same time, the divergence between explicit control in authoritarian systems and tacit mechanisms in democratic contexts shows how Western states, while claiming adherence to free expression, deploy "soft" censorship tactics that often escape scrutiny. This duality sustains the false binary of the “free West” versus the “authoritarian East,” masking the global nature of censorship.

The existing indices used to measure censorship are inadequate for capturing these nuanced dynamics. Future research must integrate qualitative assessments, algorithmic audits, and user-centered metrics to reflect the full spectrum of information control. Understanding practices like algorithmic downranking in

democratic systems or the influence of geopolitical alliances on censorship exportation can provide a more balanced and accurate picture.

CENSORSHIP LEVEL	ACTORS ENGAGED	TECHNIQUES USED	REGIONS
Soft	Private platforms (e.g., Meta, Google), civil society pressures	Algorithmic ranking, shadow banning, content downranking, community moderation	Western democracies, global tech ecosystems
Moderate	Governments in democratic or transitional states, ISPs	Content removal requests, platform regulation (e.g., misinformation laws), bandwidth throttling	Transitional democracies (e.g., Brazil, Turkey), semi-authoritarian regimes
Hard	Authoritarian regimes (e.g., China, Russia, Iran), state-owned ISPs	Firewalls, deep packet inspection, keyword filtering, internet blackouts, data localization mandates	Authoritarian states (e.g., China, Russia, Iran), export zones for censorship tools

Private platforms and ISPs are central to this dynamic, acting as both enablers of state-driven censorship and architects of their own content control regimes. Transparent moderation policies, standardized reporting, and independent oversight are critical for mitigating their impact. However, these efforts must be coupled with broader initiatives to empower users through digital literacy, anti-censorship toolkits, and public awareness of platform biases.

The global ecosystem of censorship reflects a shared struggle over the control of information, with states, corporations, and users pulling in different directions. Democratic states must confront their own complicity in shaping discourse through indirect controls, even as they critique more explicit authoritarian practices. The framing of censorship as a strictly “Eastern” problem is both inaccurate and counterproductive, obscuring the pervasive and often invisible mechanisms that operate globally.

As digital censorship evolves, so does resistance. Collaborative efforts among policymakers, technologists, civil society, and users are vital to counter these trends. By recognizing the shared dynamics of censorship across regimes and rejecting simplistic binaries, we can work toward a digital future that upholds pluralism, transparency, and the right to free expression for all.